

Seminar # 9:
CHRISTIAN STEWARDSHIP

Steward comes from the Greek word *oikomos*: *oiko* and *remo*, meaning “to arrange or manage.” In the New Testament, a steward is one who manages, administers and takes care that which belongs to someone else. He is appointed by the owner and entrusted to keep the estate running smoothly.

Since God is the One who gives every material blessing, we acknowledge His ownership (1Chronicles 29:14; James 1:17). *Christian stewardship*, then, is the supervision and management of our Christian lives.

I. THINGS TO MANAGE OR SUPERVISE

The responsibilities entrusted to us are three-fold: those of time, talents and money.

A. Time (Ephesians 5:15-16)

Pastor Jeremiah writes, “There is a gift which comes to us from a royal source each day of our lives, bright and sparkling, absolutely untouched, unspoiled. This is the priceless gift of time. Each day we receive a fresh 24 hours, 1,440 seconds, 24 hours we have never lived before and 24 hours we shall never live again.”

B. Talents (Matthew 25:14-30; Luke 12:37; 1Corinthians 7:7, 12:8-11, 28)

There are three things to remember about our talents:

1. God has wisely given each individual a talent [or talents] to use for His glory (1Corinthians 12:11-28).
2. What we do with what we have will be the basis of our judgment (Luke 19:11-27).
3. If we do not use our talent for God, we will lose it (Matthew 25:24-30).

C. Money

Twelve out of the thirty-eight parables in the New Testament has to do with money. In Matthew, Mark and Luke, one out of six verses is about money. Why? 100% of what we have comes from God and what we do with all our treasures is important to Him. Like in every other area of stewardship, God is interested in the whole picture, not just a percentage.

In the light of all these, we stewards [believers] completely belong to God alone. We do not belong to ourselves or to anyone else. Our time, money, possession and talents all belong to God (Romans 14:7-9; Luke 16:1-2, 10-13).

FORMS OF GIVING

Christ gave His life for us because of His great love. In return, we, too, should give everything to the Lord. Though we cannot outgive Him, it is our responsibility to give Him what is due to Him.

There are many forms of giving:

a. **Tithing**

This is not only an Old Testament principle [and practice], but a New Testament as well. Tithing is the giving of 10% of what we have unto the Lord. In terms of income, it should be 10% of our gross income (Malachi 3:10).

a.1. The Practice of Tithing

1. ***Tithing before the dispensation of the law***

- o According to ancient authorities such as Origen, Jerome and Chrysostum, the early church both taught and practiced tithing.
- o Tithe – giving before the time of the law (Genesis 14:18-20; Hebrews 7:10)

2. ***Tithing during the dispensation of the law***

- o Tithing during the time of Moses (Leviticus 27:30-33; Numbers 18:21-24; Deuteronomy 12:5-6)
- o All Israelites were commanded by God to bring their tithes into the “Holy Place which the Lord our God shall choose” even unto His habitation.

3. ***Tithing during the period of the kings and of the prophets*** (2Chronicles 31:5-12; Nehemiah 10:37; Malachi 3:8-12)

- o Whenever good kings who kept Israel in the true worship of God reigned, the practice of tithing was upheld. Whenever the nation forgot God fully, the prophets were sent with a message of rebuke, correction and instruction to call them back to full obedience.
- o A nation under curse (Malachi 3:8-9; Deuteronomy 28:15; Psalm 37:22; James 4:17)
- o Whether a person is rich or poor, withholding from God is robbing God and will not help him either spiritually or materially.

4. ***Tithing in Jesus’ Teaching***

- o Jesus condemned the Pharisees for their hypocrisy. (Matthew 6:2,5,16; Luke 18:9-14)
- o Praying, fasting, giving of alms, witnessing, righteous living and giving of tithes are not condemned, but hypocrisy in anything we do is condemned.
- o Jesus Himself censured that justice, mercy and faithfulness should be practiced without the neglect of tithing. (Matthew 23:23; Luke 11:42)

a.2. Blessings in Tithing (Malachi 3:10-12)

Tithing...

1. *brings meat in God's house (v. 10).*
2. *prompts the superabundant outpouring of all needed blessings (v. 10).*
3. *reverses the curse of the devourer (v. 11).*
4. *causes all the nations to call you blessed (v. 12).*

b. Offering

This is giving something out of the 90% of what we have after deducting our tithes unto the Lord. (Psalms 96:18)

c. Love Gifts (2 Corinthians 9:7)

This is almost similar to our offering except that it is given specifically to a particular person or organization that has been a blessing to you.

d. Pledges (2 Corinthians 9:7)

This is a promise unto the Lord wherein a particular amount of money is given and intended for a special purpose.

II. HOW TO GIVE

We must give...

- A. willingly. (2 Corinthians 8:12-15, 9:17)
- B. according to our ability and possession. (Acts 2:42-47; Deuteronomy 16,17)
- C. according to the example of Jesus. (2Corinthians 8:9; 1John 2:6; 1Peter 2:21)
- D. according to the example of the early believers. (John 12:1-8; Acts 4:32-37)
- E. in proportion to the desired blessing. (Luke 6:38; Matthew 19:29)
- F. at every opportunity. (Galatians 9-10)

III. BLESSINGS IN GIVING

We are...

1. blessed according to how we give (2Corinthians 9:6-11; Luke 6:38; Malachi 3:8-12)
2. supplied with all our needs here and now (Philippians 4:18-19; Proverbs 11:24)
3. assured of great reward in heaven (Matthew 6:19-21; Luke 16:9-12; 1Timothy 6:17-19)